

Film

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In the last three decades there have been five major edited collections giving form to the breadth and trajectory of film geography research. Uniting each of these works is the lurking reified construct of the real/reel, a binary understanding of film and media as a re-presentation of reality. With the release of Burgess and Gold's *Geography, the Media and Popular Culture* in 1985 a sustained inquiry into film by geographers had begun. This was a landmark book in geography because it broke from the normative belief that media and popular culture are mere entertainment. Although this and Zonn's book, *Place Images in Media* (1990), had some chapters on film, it was not until Aitken and Zonn's *Place, Power, Situation and Spectacle* (1994) that a full volume was dedicated to film geography. Whereas Burgess and Gold (1985) and Zonn (1990) had unwittingly operated through a real/reel perspective, it was not until Aitken and Zonn (1994) that the binary was identified and challenged. In *Engaging Film* (2002), Cresswell and Dixon argued that the textual metaphor, or a hermeneutic approach, had become hegemonic in film geography. This assertion was significant because it pointed to the way that the text/context couplet that the textual metaphor relies upon reinforces the binary logic of re-presentation. In *The Geography Cinema: A Cinematic World* (2008), Lukinbeal and Zimmermann argue that while film geography

includes research on text, it also includes a focus on film form and the affects generated by film, which provide new avenues of research beyond representation. The history of the real/reel binary sketched here provides an entry point to key debates within this subfield including hermeneutics and other supporting binaries such as material/nonmaterial, direct/indirect experience, and subject/object.

Beginning in the late 1980s and early 1990s geographers began discussing issues associated with the cultural turn and crisis of representation. Of importance to film geography is the questioning of the reification of a series of binaries ingrained in geographic thinking that control and delimit the terrain of representational studies and how film and media are positioned within them. First were the debates over the cultural turn in geography, best illustrated by the Price and Lewis dialog in 1993 in the *Annals of the Association of American Geographers* (hereafter *Annals*). Whereas those cultural geographers following the Berkeley School tradition privileged material artifacts as indicators of the transformation of natural landscape to cultural landscape, the new cultural geographers questioned the discursive construction of categories such as "natural" or "cultural," thus shifting the conversation to landscape (and other primitives) as nonmaterial representations. It is difficult to imagine the subfield of film geography appearing if not for the passionate offense of the new cultural geographers in their then-unorthodox assertion of the legitimacy of the nonmaterial as an object of geographical inquiry. This debate between traditional and new cultural geographers was not felt only in cultural geography, however, but paralleled the normative belief throughout

geography during the 1980s that film and media do not have the power to effect true change in the material conditions of everyday life and are mere entertainment, not a part of high culture.

Despite these important dialogs, the legacy of the turn was the production of a politicized binary empowered to police and regulate knowledge production. The result of the cultural turn for film geography was the reification of the material/nonmaterial binary. Taken in conjunction with the crisis of representation, the cultural turn helped generate a second binary, that between direct and indirect experiences.

The crisis of representation blurred any clear distinction between a direct and indirect experience of the world by challenging our ability to access a reality not mediated through cultural ways of knowing. The roots of this binary can be traced even further, however, to environmental perception and humanist geography's rebellion against the mimetic beliefs of the quantitative revolution. The solidification of this binary at that time was significantly aided by Lowenthal's essay in the *Annals* in 1961, which emphasized sensory perception as the dominant mode of understanding. Both the material/nonmaterial and direct/indirect binaries position film as holding less value in terms of knowledge production because research on film is perceived as not dealing with things that are real or directly experienced. Equally problematic is that they fuel film geography's recurring ontological distinction between the real and the reel.

The real/reel binary is the idea that film is a representation of reality, a mode of theorizing that has two important outcomes. First, there is a continual deferral of meaning production away from film and onto seemingly more important thematic areas like gender, sexuality, race, colonialism, or class. Second, the emphasis placed on epistemology by poststructuralism reinforces hermeneutics as the dominant mode

of film analysis, thus keeping the focus of film geography on reading narratives and exposing underlying or hidden meaning. Hermeneutics, or textual analysis, can be understood as the author-text-reader (ATR) model. Research using this approach frequently focuses on understanding the films' constructed meanings and the power relations that produce them by focusing on one of the three given modalities.

An author-centered approach focuses on how the text is influenced by the conditions of production, including the filmmakers, cast and crew, location of production, and sociohistorical milieu. Dixon and Grimes (2004), for example, use good and bad dialectics as a trope to explore the production site of *Tarzan's Secret Treasure*. They argue that while a bad dialectic actively deploys the real/reel binary, leading to essentialized identities, a good dialectic sees the real and reel as relational, leaving these categories open. Using transactionalism and psychoanalysis, Aitken and Zonn (1993) interrogate gender and landscape in the films of Peter Weir. Through an auteurist reading they find that these films resonate with themes of ecofeminism and how class and gender construct cultural identity. Lukinbeal (2012) explores the production of the cinematic landscape of San Diego using spatial analysis and performance theory. Rather than an examination of a single text, Lukinbeal shows how a landscape is a palimpsest, continually produced by individuals working in the regional film industry.

A text-centered approach critiques the production of reality and seeks to uncover naturalized ideological claims. Natter and Jones (1993), for instance, investigate how class and power lead to the imaging of public/private spaces in Michael Moore's *Roger and Me*. Using a dialectic understanding of the real/reel binary they contest the notion of objectivity and narrative neutrality in documentary films. Lukinbeal and Aitken (1998) explore the power relations

embedded in masculinity through films by Gus van Sant. Through a framework of psychoanalysis and scale they show how masculinity is a battleground where hysteria is ensconced. Dando (2005) examines the film *Boys Don't Cry*, looking at how gendered landscapes are constructed, policed, and transgressed. She shows that the plains are more than a mere frontier zone dividing civilization from the wilderness. The plains are also a place where meaning and identity oscillate and are constantly reworked.

The reader-centered approach focuses on the diversity of reception. In their book, *The Place of the Audience*, Jancovich, Faire, and Stubbings point out four areas of film reception studies: one, the audience as market; two, the situatedness of reception; three, ethnographies of reception; and four, exhibition. The audience as market examines preference, demographics, and how the film industry conceives the audience. The situatedness of reception is archival in nature, as it explores movie reviews, marketing material, and other media to contextualize the reception of a film to a social group within a given era. Ethnographies of reception engage the everyday practices and motivations of viewing and the social activity of cinema going. Finally, exhibition studies examine the historically and geographically contingent sites of reception, emphasizing the architecture within which films are viewed. Bypassing these four approaches, Kennedy (2008) takes an autobiographical look at how film has impacted her own life, suggesting that our lives are so mediated it is difficult to distinguish between real and reel.

Inherent to reader-centered analyses are the issues of relativism and essentialism. Where essentialism appears when found meaning is granted the authority to speak for everyone's viewpoint, relativism exposes that essentialism has been naturalized. Essentialism further underlies the assumption that there is an

archetypal (male, white, young, middle class) text-centered subject that consumes a film's meaning, when in fact there is an infinite array of possible outcomes. While the poststructuralist belief in the "death of the author" has been much discussed in theory, there is a lack of research by geographers on understanding the relativism of meaning reception.

The power of the ATR model lies in its ability to help methodologically organize an investigation of a film; however, when the ATR model is constructed through linguistics and optical theories, an epistemological trap is created that prevents one from getting outside of the text, thus reinforcing the real/reel binary. The problem with this conceptualization is that images are not text and film is more than an image. In the book *Picture Theory* (1995) W.J.T. Mitchell points out that images and texts are two different types of representations; we have very few theories to explain images. Furthermore, we are undergoing a pictorial turn, where the era of language is being swept aside by images. At issue here is how we conceive of film and cinema: when we conceptualize film as representation there is an assumed sensory understanding that privileges vision and immobility, a heterology.

A heterological viewer, or voyeur, separates the subject (the viewer) from the object (the film). Rather than conceiving the spectatorial event as a segregation between subject and object, in *Atlas of Emotion* (2002) Bruno argues for a haptical mobilization that turns the voyeur into a voyageur; the spectator is no longer chained in Plato's cave, but free to wander. Haptics focuses on corporeality and the porous boundary between inside and outside, the skin, thereby repositioning our attention to the sense of touching and being touched. This redirection occurs not merely as an add-on to vision, but as an emotional resonance affecting the body. Etymologically, emotion can be traced to both feelings

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and movement. A focus on optics positions the viewing subject as occupying a reel or real space, which produces an indexical relationship between image and reality. The move from optics to haptics mobilizes the spectator and shifts the attention from sightseeing to site-seeing. The focus on site is not about a real signified grounding the reel, but rather is about a reconfiguration of place through embodied movement.

SEE ALSO: Cultural turn; Poststructuralism/poststructural geographies

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